

Employee Handbook

Practical guidance for employment, leave, conduct, and employee support

Owner	People Operations
Effective date	January 1, 2026
Review cycle	Annual
Applies to	Northstar Labs employees

This is a fictional policy created for knowledge-management testing. Names, contacts, amounts, and procedures are illustrative and do not describe a real employer.

Quick reference

The Employee Handbook applies to all Northstar Labs employees unless a local employment agreement or mandatory law provides a more favorable benefit. Contractors should follow their services agreement and the site security rules, not the employee benefit provisions.

For leave questions, submit a PeopleHub request or contact people@northstarlabs.example. For urgent workplace safety concerns, contact security@northstarlabs.example and the local emergency service.

Leave type	Allowance	Request / evidence	Approval
Annual leave	25 paid days per calendar year; prorated	PeopleHub Leave Request	Manager; HR for 10+ consecutive workdays
Paid sick leave	10 days per calendar year	Notify manager before shift; medical note after 3 consecutive days	Manager records; HR reviews extended absence
Primary caregiver	16 paid weeks	Form HR-LEAVE-07 at least 30 days ahead when foreseeable	People Operations
Partner / secondary caregiver	4 paid weeks	Form HR-LEAVE-07	People Operations
Compassionate leave	Up to 5 paid days per event	Contact manager or People Operations	Manager
Jury or civic duty	Paid for required service	Official summons	People Operations

1. Employment and onboarding

1.1 Employment classifications

Full-time employees normally work at least 30 hours per week and receive the benefits described in this handbook. Part-time employees receive benefits where the relevant plan states that they are eligible. Fixed-term employees are eligible during their stated employment period. Employment classification does not change without a written notice from People Operations.

1.2 First 90 days

New employees complete identity verification, payroll enrollment, security training, acceptable-use training, and role-specific onboarding within their first 10 business days. Managers set a 30-day role plan and conduct check-ins at approximately 30, 60, and 90 days. The introductory period is not a guarantee of employment for any duration.

1.3 Employee records

Employees must update their home address, emergency contact, tax withholding, bank account, and legal name in PeopleHub. Payroll changes submitted after the monthly payroll cutoff on the 18th may take effect in the following pay cycle. People Operations restricts personnel-file access to authorized staff and legally required disclosures.

2. Working time, attendance, and location

2.1 Core collaboration hours

Teams establish schedules suitable for their customers and time zones. Unless a manager publishes a different schedule, core collaboration hours are 10:00 to 15:00 local time Monday through Thursday. Employees are expected to attend required meetings, maintain an accurate calendar, and tell their manager promptly when an

emergency affects availability.

2.2 Flexible and remote work

Hybrid employees may work remotely up to three days per week when their role and team plan permit it. A recurring arrangement involving another state, province, or country requires People Operations and Tax approval before work begins. Employees may not treat short business travel as permission to relocate. Submit a Location Change Request at least 30 days before a planned move.

2.3 Time reporting and overtime

Non-exempt employees record all working time in TimeTrack by noon each Monday for the preceding week. Off-the-clock work is prohibited. Overtime must be approved in advance, but all hours actually worked must still be reported and will be paid according to applicable law. A missed time entry should be corrected with the manager and Payroll within five business days.

3. Time off and leave

3.1 Annual leave

Full-time employees accrue 25 days of paid annual leave per calendar year, prorated for partial years of service and part-time schedules. Leave accrues monthly and may be used after it appears in PeopleHub. Employees may carry up to five unused days into the next calendar year; carried days expire on March 31 unless local law requires otherwise.

- Submit ordinary annual leave at least five business days before the first day away.
- Submit requests for 10 or more consecutive workdays at least 30 days ahead when reasonably possible; People Operations must review these requests.
- Managers consider customer coverage, project deadlines, fairness among employees, and previously approved leave. A request is not approved until PeopleHub shows Approved.
- Illness during annual leave may be reclassified as sick leave when the employee promptly reports it and provides evidence required by local policy.

3.2 Sick and medical leave

Employees receive 10 paid sick days per calendar year. Sick leave may be used for the employee's illness, preventive appointment, mental-health care, or care of an immediate family member. Notify the manager before the scheduled start time when possible. A medical note is required after more than three consecutive workdays, but it should confirm work restrictions or duration rather than disclose an unnecessary diagnosis.

3.3 Family, compassionate, and civic leave

Primary caregivers receive up to 16 paid weeks and partner or secondary caregivers receive up to four paid weeks following birth, adoption, or foster placement. Submit Form HR-LEAVE-07 at least 30 days in advance when the event is foreseeable. People Operations coordinates statutory leave, benefits continuation, and return-to-work dates. Compassionate leave provides up to five paid days per event for the death or critical illness of an immediate family member. Required jury or civic service is paid when the employee supplies the official notice.

3.4 Unpaid and extended leave

When paid and statutory leave are unavailable, an employee may request unpaid personal leave. Requests longer than 10 workdays require the manager, department vice president, and People Operations. Approval depends on

business coverage and does not guarantee that the same assignment will remain available, subject to applicable law.

4. Pay, benefits, and development

4.1 Payroll and salary bands

Salaried employees are paid monthly on the last banking day; hourly employees are paid twice monthly. The separate Salary Bands and Progression Guide describes ranges, placement, promotions, and exception approvals. A salary-band midpoint is a reference for a fully proficient employee, not an automatic salary target or guaranteed increase.

4.2 Performance cycle

Employees and managers set written goals by February 15, hold a mid-year conversation in June or July, and complete the annual review by November 30. Ratings consider results, role expectations, collaboration, judgment, and company values. A rating does not mechanically determine compensation; budget, market position, internal equity, and sustained performance are considered together.

4.3 Learning support

Full-time employees may use up to USD 1,500 per calendar year for approved courses, books, certifications, or conferences related to their current role or an agreed development plan. Manager approval is required before purchase. Travel and meals follow the Finance Expense and Travel Policy and do not come from the learning allowance unless Finance states otherwise.

5. Conduct, safety, and information security

5.1 Respectful workplace

Discrimination, harassment, retaliation, bullying, threats, and deliberate humiliation are prohibited. Concerns may be reported to a manager, People Operations, legal@northstarlabs.example, or the confidential Ethics Line. Employees do not need to confront the person involved before reporting. Retaliation against a person who raises a good-faith concern or assists an investigation is prohibited.

5.2 Conflicts, gifts, and outside activity

Employees must disclose a personal, financial, family, or outside-business interest that could influence company decisions. Gifts from a current or potential supplier must not exceed USD 100 in aggregate per source per year without written Legal approval. Cash and cash equivalents are never acceptable. Outside employment must not compete with Northstar Labs, use company confidential information, or interfere with work obligations.

5.3 Security and acceptable use

Use company-managed devices for company data, enable multi-factor authentication, and report suspected phishing, device loss, or unauthorized access immediately to security@northstarlabs.example. Confidential information must be stored only in approved systems. Employees may not paste company confidential information into public generative-AI services or personal cloud storage.

6. Employee changes and departures

6.1 Internal transfers and promotions

Employees normally need six months in their current role and satisfactory performance before applying internally, although People Operations may waive this guideline. A transfer becomes effective only after the current and receiving managers, People Operations, and Finance confirm the role, level, location, and compensation in writing.

6.2 Resignation and offboarding

Employees are asked to give at least two weeks' written notice unless their agreement states otherwise. Before the final day, employees return equipment, transfer records, submit outstanding expenses, and remove company data from authorized personal devices. Confidentiality and intellectual-property obligations continue after employment as stated in applicable agreements.

7. Questions, exceptions, and policy ownership

People Operations owns this handbook and may interpret it consistently with applicable law. A manager cannot privately waive a requirement. Requests for exceptions must be documented and approved by People Operations and, where financial, tax, security, or legal risk exists, by the responsible function. The latest published version in PeopleHub controls over downloaded copies.

Topic	Primary contact	Expected response
Leave, benefits, employee records	people@northstarlabs.example	Two business days
Payroll or time reporting	payroll@northstarlabs.example	Two business days
Safety or security incident	security@northstarlabs.example	Immediately / 24x7
Ethics, harassment, retaliation	Ethics Line or legal@northstarlabs.example	Acknowledgment within one business day